

Daily Economic Briefing

Friday 25 September 2026 | Window: Wed 23 Sept 20:00 ET – Thu 24 Sept 20:20 ET (Thu 24 Sept session) | Research cutoff Thu 24 Sept 20:20 ET | Edition 28

Assumptions, corrections and status this edition

- Correction:** Wednesday 23 Sept's 2-year Treasury close, unresolved at edition 27 (only an implausible 4.10% reading was found and discarded), is now confirmed via a fresh FRED/H.15 pull at **4.85%**^[26]. Treat 4.85% as the standing Wednesday baseline.
- All four Thursday central-bank decisions previewed last edition landed as expected on the same day: Norges Bank hiked, Riksbank/SNB/Banxico held. SNB's date is now directly confirmed against snb.ch (Thursday 24 Sept, not Friday 25th as one earlier edition had it) — closes a two-edition open thread^[22].
- The CBOE vol feed (VIX9D/VIX3M/VIX6M/VVIX/SKEW) returned a full, individually-timestamp-verified clean sweep this run, recovering from Wednesday's "full stale sweep" failure^[36].
- October-hike odds moved sharply and sources disagree on the scale of the move: Polymarket approx. 65-67% (up from approx. 54-56% last edition); CME FedWatch secondary citations split this run between approx. 54% (likely a stale republich) and approx. 73-73.5% following Wednesday's Barr remarks — not reconciled, both reported. Kalshi failed direct fetch a sixth straight edition (HTTP 429).
- Thursday's own 10-year Treasury close has not yet posted to FRED (T+1 lag; expected Friday). Secondary coverage disagrees on the exact intraday high (approx. 5.10% vs. approx. 5.22%), though both describe it as the highest since 2007; the 30-year's 5.43% print (highest since 2004) is corroborated by two independent sources and is more solidly sourced.
- Index closes sourced via the AP wire (through WTOP/ABC News); the S&P 500 closing level cross-checks exactly against an independent Yahoo Finance pull^[1]^[3].

60-second read

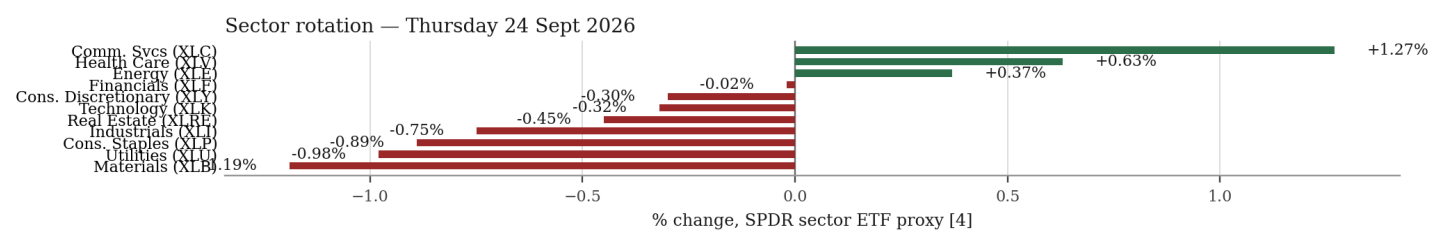
- Headline indices closed almost exactly where they started — S&P 500 -0.1%, Dow -0.3%, Nasdaq +0.1% — masking a volatile session underneath: bond yields pushed to fresh multi-year highs (30-year 5.43%, highest since 2004) as hot data and hawkish Fed rhetoric kept the hike case alive, pulling October-hike odds sharply higher across every venue that could be checked.
- All four previewed Thursday central-bank decisions landed: Norges Bank hiked 25bp to 4.50% (hawkish), while Riksbank (1.75%), SNB (0%) and Banxico (6.50%) all held — SNB's long-uncertain decision date is now confirmed directly against its own site.
- Oil spiked on a Houthi missile strike on Saudi cities (Brent briefly topped \$108) before paring to close Brent +3.4% at \$106.60 and WTI +2.7% at \$94.61 on reports of US-Iran talks toward a phased Strait of Hormuz reopening.
- Single-name action dominated the tape: MGM Resorts -11.0% after Barry Diller's People Inc. withdrew its take-private bid; Oracle -3.5% on a force-majeure notice tied to a delayed Stargate data-center gas pipeline; Meta +4.5% (best month since 2013) as it detailed Muse AI-agent monetization at Connect — a partner-fee framing, not pure bypass, that let Wednesday's Muse-driven travel selloff partially reverse (Expedia +1.1%, Airbnb +1.2%).
- The Trump-Xi summit culminated Thursday with a state dinner and, per Treasury Secretary Bessent, an extension of the US-China trade truce to January 10, 2027 — no comprehensive new deal and no Taiwan breakthrough reported.

1. Market recap

S&P 500 7,704.13 -1.90 (-0.1%)	Dow Jones 51,349.98 -161.61 (-0.3%)	Nasdaq Comp. 26,939.37 +3.34 (+0.1%)	Russell 2000 2,835.57 -3.09 (-0.1%)	VIX 15.67 +0.49 (+3.2%)	10Y Treasury approx. 5.1-5.2% fresh 19-yr-area high
---	--	---	--	--------------------------------------	--

A genuine whipsaw session: the AP wire's own characterization — stocks "ended the day roughly back where they started after whipping through a couple reversals" — is the most accurate one-line summary, echoed independently by a separately-sourced wrap headlined "a shaky day for oil prices and the bond market"^{[1][2]}. Weekly performance improved despite Thursday's flatness: S&P +0.7%, Nasdaq +1.6% for the week, while Dow -0.6% and Russell -0.9% lagged^[1]. Underneath the calm index-level print, Treasuries sold off hard (30-year to 5.43%, highest since 2004) after Wednesday's hot flash PMI and Fed Governor Barr's hawkish remarks continued to reverberate, reinforced Thursday by a jobless-claims beat (197,000, lowest since mid-July) and a strong new-home-sales print (684,000 SAAR, +6.4% m/m)^{[27][28]}. The independently-sourced S&P close (7,704.13) matches exactly between the AP wire and a Yahoo Finance cross-check, giving high confidence in the headline level despite the surrounding volatility^{[1][3]}.

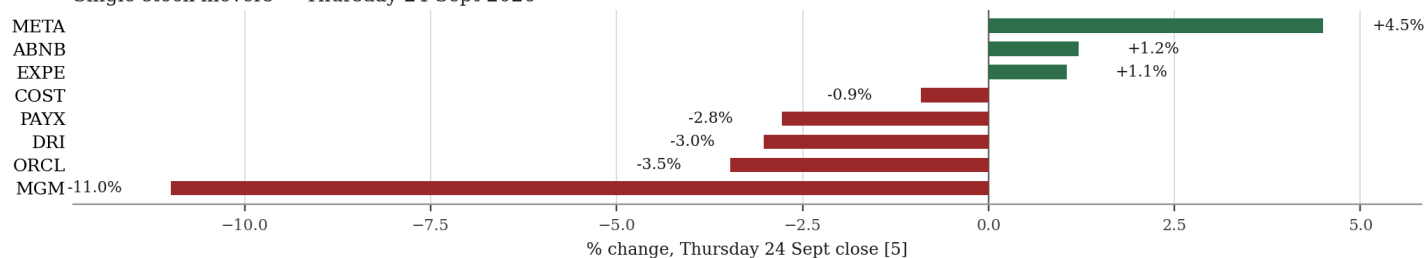
2. Equities and earnings



Sector leadership flipped entirely from Wednesday's Energy-only-positive, rate-driven pattern: Communication Services (XLC +1.27%) led on Meta's rally, followed by Health Care (XLV +0.63%) and Energy (XLE +0.37%, still positive on the oil spike); Materials (XLB -1.19%) and Utilities (XLU -0.98%) lagged. Financials (XLF -0.02%) stabilized further after two rough sessions^[4].

Single-stock movers

Single-stock movers — Thursday 24 Sept 2026



Ticker	Move	Driver
MGM Resorts	-10.99%	Barry Diller's People Inc. withdrew its \$48.30/share take-private bid, erasing the takeover premium; Diller keeps his 27% stake and says he remains open to alternatives ^[6]
Oracle	-3.47%	Sent a force-majeure notice to developer Blue Owl Capital on the Stargate New Mexico AI data center, tied to a delayed gas-pipeline commissioning that threatens the 2028 target; Oracle says the project stays on schedule, Blue Owl disputes any change to financial commitments ^[7]
Darden Restaurants	-3.02%	Fiscal Q1 EPS \$2.05 vs. \$2.06 consensus, revenue \$3.20bn vs. \$3.206bn consensus — a razor-thin miss; Olive Garden same-store growth slowed, though shares pared a deeper intraday drop after CEO comments on improving Sept trends ^[9]
Paychex	-2.78%	Second-day continuation of Wednesday's -8.77% earnings-quality selloff (GAAP EPS below adjusted EPS, weak free cash flow), no new news identified Thursday ^[5]
Costco	-0.91% regular; muted AH	Q4/FY2026 results reported after Thursday's close: EPS \$6.75 vs. approx. \$6.55 consensus, comparable sales +9.4%, FY revenue \$303.15bn (+10.1% y/y) — both beats, but approx. \$0.15/share of the EPS beat was a non-recurring tariff refund; after-hours reaction was muted (approx. +0.2%), with the fuller market verdict falling in Friday's session, outside this window ^[10]
Expedia / Airbnb	+1.05% / +1.21%	Partial reversal of Wednesday's Muse-driven selloff (EXPE -7.72%, ABNB -7.56%) after Meta detailed Muse's travel integration as a partner-fee model routed through Expedia rather than a pure bypass ^{[8][5]}
Meta Platforms	+4.50%	Up approx. 30% in September, best month since 2013, after detailing Muse AI-agent monetization at Connect (retail integrations with Walmart, Best Buy, Gap, Sephora, Wayfair; travel booking via Expedia); JPMorgan called Muse's potential "dominant," Cantor Fitzgerald raised its price target to \$860 from \$680 ^[8]

Analyst actions confirmed Thursday: Oppenheimer reiterated Outperform on Dynatrace and raised its price target to \$71 from \$60, adding the name to its Top Picks list on AI-observability momentum^[11]. Jefferies kept Edison International at Hold but cut its target to \$53 from \$68^[12]. Citi initiated Rivian at Neutral with an \$18 target^[13]. Bank of America maintained Buy on Ecolab with a \$342 target (approx. 24% implied upside), framing its CoolIT Systems and Ovivo acquisitions as a data-center liquid-cooling and semiconductor ultrapure-water growth story^[14].

3. Macro, policy and rates

Fed Chair Kevin Warsh and the October 27-28, 2026 FOMC date were both re-confirmed fresh directly against federalreserve.gov this run^{[15][16]}. All four central-bank decisions previewed last edition landed Thursday, all confirmed against each bank's own site or high-quality wire coverage: **Norges Bank** hiked 25bp to 4.50% (from 4.25%), a hawkish surprise with Governor Wolden Bache signaling further hikes are possible^{[17][18]}; **Riksbank** held at 1.75%, matching all 18 economists in a Bloomberg survey, but flagged a greater chance of a Q4 hike^{[19][20]}; **SNB** held at 0% and raised its inflation forecasts to 0.7%/0.8%/0.8% for 2026-28, partly on higher oil prices — confirmed directly via snb.ch, closing the date uncertainty carried since edition 26^{[22][23]}; **Banxico** held at 6.50% unanimously, saying Mexico "does not have to react automatically" to the Fed^[21].

Rate-path odds jumped sharply on the week's hawkish drumbeat, though sources disagree on the scale: Polymarket showed approx. 65-67% probability of an October hike (up from approx. 54-56% last edition)^[42]; CME FedWatch secondary citations split this run between approx. 54% (likely stale) and approx. 73-73.5% (following Wednesday's Barr remarks and hot PMI) — both reported rather than reconciled to one figure. Kalshi's direct fetch failed for a sixth consecutive edition (HTTP 429). The Trump-Xi Washington summit culminated Thursday with the main bilateral meeting, a military ceremony and a state dinner attended by Tim Cook, Jensen Huang and Sam Altman among others^[25]; Treasury Secretary Bessent said the two sides agreed to extend the US-China trade truce to January 10, 2027, with no comprehensive new deal or Taiwan breakthrough reported^[24]. A fresh FRED pull resolved Wednesday's 2-year Treasury close at 4.85% (10-year 5.11%, in line with the previously reported 5.09-5.14% range); Thursday's own closes have not yet posted (T+1 lag)^[26]. SOFR's most recent published reading remained 3.87% (Wednesday, T+1 lag)^[40].

4. Commodities and FX

Instrument	Level	Chg	Note
WTI crude (Nov)	\$94.61/bbl	+2.7%	Houthi missile strikes on Saudi cities spiked prices intraday before US-Iran Hormuz-reopening talk reports pared the move ^[30]
Brent crude (Nov)	\$106.60/bbl	+3.4%	Intraday high above \$108; same driver as WTI, no contract-roll mismatch this session ^[30]
Gold (Kitco)	\$4,273.20/oz	approx. -0.6%	Kitco-vs-USAGOLD gap, tracked over three editions (\$50 → \$7 → now), has essentially closed ^[31]
Gold (USAGOLD)	\$4,273.36/oz	-0.32%	\$0.16 apart from Kitco — the narrowing trend now looks resolved rather than coincidental ^[32]
Copper (Westmetall/LME)	\$14,765.00/t	+0.20%	lme.com/metal.com remain unusable (6th straight failure); Westmetall fallback continues to work cleanly ^[33]

DXY	101.29	+0.19%	Yahoo Finance read; TradingEconomics showed 101.08/-0.02%, a direction-level disagreement disclosed rather than resolved ^{[34][35]}
EUR/USD	1.1382	-0.58%	Directionally consistent with DXY's dollar-strength read, unlike Wednesday's magnitude mismatch ^[34]
GBP/USD	1.3242	-0.76%	^[34]
USD/JPY	158.27	+0.51%	^[34]

Oil's rally was driven by an escalation-then-de-escalation cycle: a Houthi missile strike on Saudi cities pushed Brent briefly above \$108 before a senior Iranian official told Reuters the "most realistic path forward" involves Tehran allowing Strait of Hormuz navigation in exchange for the US ending its naval blockade, and reports emerged of New York-based US-Iran talks on a phased reopening — both crudes still closed sharply higher on net^[30]. Gold gave back ground as the firmer dollar, higher yields and rising hike odds offset Iran-driven safe-haven demand; the Kitco/USAGOLD divergence that had run as wide as approx. \$50 two editions ago is now down to \$0.16, though each vendor's own stated day-over-day % (approx. -0.6% vs. -0.32%) still implies a different Wednesday baseline — a residual reconciliation gap worth one more edition of tracking^{[31][32]}. Henry Hub natural gas could not be pinned to a precise day-over-day change this run (see Annex A).

Commodities & FX levels — Wednesday baseline vs. Thursday close

Instrument	Wed 23 Sept close	Thu 24 Sept close	Chg
WTI crude (Nov contract)	\$92.16	\$94.61	+2.7%
Brent crude (Nov contract)	\$103.08	\$106.60	+3.4%
Gold (Kitco)	\$4,297.53	\$4,273.20	-0.57%
Gold (USAGOLD)	\$4,304.11	\$4,273.36	-0.71% vs. this baseline (own stated: -0.32%, see above)
Copper (Westmetall/LME cash)	\$14,735.00	\$14,765.00	+0.20%
DXY	101.10	101.29	+0.19%
EUR/USD	1.1448	1.1382	-0.58%
GBP/USD	1.3343	1.3242	-0.76%
USD/JPY	157.46	158.27	+0.51%
VIX	15.18	15.67	+3.23%

5. Derivatives, volatility and positioning

VIX closed 15.67, +3.23% vs. Wednesday's 15.18, confirmed identically by a direct Cboe delayed-quotes pull and an independent Yahoo Finance cross-check^[36]. The full vol complex returned fresh, individually timestamp-verified readings for the first time in two editions: VIX9D 14.11 (+4.9%), VIX3M 18.43 (+1.8%), VIX6M 20.35 (+1.2%), VVIX 90.57 (+2.2%), SKEW 146.04 (-0.1%)^[36]. Notably, spot VIX (15.67) now sits above VIX9D (14.11) — a front-end inversion worth watching, plausibly a lagged echo of the 16 Sept FOMC aging further out of the 9-day window. Cboe's options-volume page had not yet posted a Thursday figure as of the research cutoff; separately, this run surfaced an unresolved methodology mismatch between the total-volume figure logged last edition (902,421 contracts) and a same-page Wednesday re-read (13,781,355 contracts) that is roughly 15x larger, likely a different aggregation category on the same URL — neither number should be treated as comparable to the other until this is resolved (see Annex A)^[37]. SpotGamma failed a sixth consecutive edition (no live data behind its paywall); zerogex.io produced a second consecutive clean, dated read — net SPX dealer gamma +\$3.63bn (down from +\$9.47bn Wednesday), flip level 7,698, reconciling well against the 7,704.13 close and now looking like a repeatable SpotGamma alternative rather than a one-off^[38]. CFTC CoT remains dated 15 September with no new report yet (next due approx. Friday 25 Sept, confirmed via direct cftc.gov fetch, Last-Modified header unchanged since 18 Sept)^[39]. Same-day options-flow color: elevated implied vol and active call skew in several AI-infrastructure-adjacent names (Nebius, Bloom Energy, Wix, GoDaddy) alongside continued Oracle put/spread activity around the force-majeure headline^[41].

6. The day ahead

Date	Event	Consensus / context
Fri 25 Sept	Durable goods orders (August)	No reliable consensus figure obtained this run; prior (July) print was +1.1% headline, +0.4% ex-transport ^[43]
Fri 25 Sept	CFTC Commitment of Traders	Next report due, covering the week of 22 Sept; would post after this window closes
Tue 30 Sept	PCE inflation (August, Personal Income and Outlays)	Confirmed via bea.gov's own release schedule, 8:30am ET ^[29]
Tue 27 – Wed 28 Oct	FOMC meeting	Odds of a 25bp hike now split approx. 54-73% depending on venue (see Section 3) — a meaningfully more contested call than last edition's mid-50s consensus

Sector setup we take into Friday's session

- Communication Services carries momentum from Meta's Muse reveal; watch whether the travel-name rebound (Expedia, Airbnb, Booking) extends or was a one-day relief bounce.
- Rate-sensitive sectors (Utilities, Real Estate, Materials) remain the weak links as long as yields keep pushing to fresh multi-year highs and hike odds stay elevated.
- Costco's fuller market reaction to its Q4/FY2026 beat falls in Friday's session — Thursday's muted after-hours move likely understates the eventual verdict either way.
- Energy stays a swing factor on any further Hormuz/Iran headlines given how sharply Thursday's rally built and partly unwound intraday.

Annex A — Data points sought but not verified this edition

- CME FedWatch October-hike probability: sources split this run between approx. 54% (likely a stale republish) and approx. 73-73.5%; could not reconcile to one figure, and the official CME tool itself timed out on direct fetch.
- Kalshi October Fed-decision odds: HTTP 429 on direct fetch, sixth consecutive edition; a search-only snippet was found but not primary-confirmed.
- Thursday's precise 10-year Treasury close: FRED has not yet posted it (T+1 lag); secondary coverage disagrees between approx. 5.10% and approx. 5.22%, both "highest since 2007."
- Henry Hub natural gas Wed-to-Thu % change: a weekly-update source implies approx. \$2.90/MMBtu, a separate aggregator implies approx. \$3.06/MMBtu — about 5% apart and not reconcilable; likely different delivery-month or averaging conventions.
- Thursday's Cboe total options volume: not yet published on the source page as of the research cutoff.
- The 902,421-vs-13,781,355-contract mismatch between this and last edition's Cboe options-volume reads: likely two different categories on the same URL, not resolved this run.
- Friday 25 Sept's durable-goods (August) consensus estimate: not located via available sources.
- Reported hawkish Thursday remarks attributed to NY Fed President John Williams: could not verify against a primary transcript; the Fed's own speeches page lists no Thursday address.
- Banxico's exact consecutive-hold streak count: Mexican-press sources disagree between a third and a fourth straight hold.
- A Thursday-dated building-permits figure: most likely a stale republish of the already-reported 17 Sept (August) print rather than new data; excluded from the main report on that basis.
- Exact wording of any Trump-Xi joint statement, including a reported agreement to "examine AI threats": no primary transcript was located this run.
- Rivian's exact Thursday closing % change and Palantir's cited Rosenblatt Securities price-target reiteration: sourced only via secondary aggregation, not independently cross-checked against a primary or stockanalysis.com close.

Annex B — Sources

- [1] AP, "How major US stock indexes fared Thursday 9/24/2026," via WTOP/ABC News, 24 Sept 2026
- [2] Washington Post syndicated wrap, "A shaky day for oil prices and the bond market..." 24 Sept 2026
- [3] Yahoo Finance, ^GSPC chart data cross-check, 24 Sept 2026
- [4] Stockanalysis.com, SPDR sector ETF (XLC/XLV/XLE/XLF/XLY/XLK/XLRE/XLI/XLP/XLU/XLB) price history, 24 Sept 2026
- [5] Stockanalysis.com, single-stock price history tables, 24 Sept 2026
- [6] CNBC, "MGM Resorts shares sink 11% as Diller's People Inc. withdraws bid," 24 Sept 2026
- [7] CNBC / Bloomberg, Oracle force-majeure notice on Blue Owl Stargate data center, 24 Sept 2026
- [8] CNBC, Meta Muse AI-agent Connect coverage and travel-integration reporting, 24 Sept 2026
- [9] CNBC, Darden Restaurants fiscal Q1 FY2027 earnings, 24 Sept 2026
- [10] Investing.com / TipRanks, Costco Q4/FY2026 earnings, 24 Sept 2026
- [11] MarketBeat / ad-hoc-news.de, Oppenheimer Dynatrace price-target raise, 24 Sept 2026
- [12] Secondary aggregator, Jefferies Edison International price-target cut, 24 Sept 2026
- [13] Secondary aggregator, Citi Rivian coverage initiation, 24 Sept 2026
- [14] Benzinga, Bank of America Ecolab price target, 24 Sept 2026
- [15] Federalreserve.gov, Board of Governors biography page (Kevin Warsh), fetched 24-25 Sept 2026
- [16] Federalreserve.gov, FOMC meeting calendar, fetched 24-25 Sept 2026
- [17] Norges-bank.no, September 2026 monetary policy decision page
- [18] Investing.com / Reuters, "Norway central bank raises interest rate, may hike again," 24 Sept 2026
- [19] Riksbank.se, policy-rate press release, 24 Sept 2026
- [20] Bloomberg, "Riksbank Holds Rate and Sees Greater Chance of Hike This Year," 24 Sept 2026
- [21] Investing.com / Reuters, "Banxico holds benchmark rate at 6.5%...", 24 Sept 2026
- [22] SNB (snb.ch), "Monetary policy assessment of 24 September 2026" press release
- [23] CNBC, "Swiss National Bank holds rates at 0%...", 24 Sept 2026
- [24] Bloomberg, "Trump-Xi buy time on trade with neither able to afford a fight," 24 Sept 2026
- [25] WhiteHouse.gov, state-arrival and state-dinner detail releases, 24 Sept 2026
- [26] FRED (fred.stlouisfed.org), DGS2 and DGS10 series, fetched 24-25 Sept 2026
- [27] Washington Times / PBS, initial jobless claims, 24 Sept 2026
- [28] Census Bureau / HUD, new home sales (August 2026), 24 Sept 2026
- [29] BEA.gov, Personal Income and Outlays release schedule
- [30] CNBC, oil-price coverage of Houthi strikes and US-Iran Hormuz talks, 24 Sept 2026
- [31] Kitco, gold AM report and charts page, 24 Sept 2026
- [32] USAGOLD, daily precious-metals market report, 24 Sept 2026
- [33] Westmetall.com, LME copper cash-settlement table
- [34] Yahoo Finance, DXY / EUR-USD / GBP-USD / USD-JPY history pages, 24 Sept 2026
- [35] TradingEconomics, DXY quote (disclosed divergence from Yahoo)
- [36] Cboe (cdn.cboe.com), delayed-quotes feed for VIX complex, 24 Sept 2026, last_trade_time verified per series
- [37] Cboe, US Options Daily Market Statistics page
- [38] Zerogex.io, SPX gamma-levels page, 24 Sept 2026
- [39] CFTC (cftc.gov), Commitment of Traders, financial_if.htm and deacboelf.htm
- [40] New York Fed markets API, SOFR rate series
- [41] Market Rebellion, Mid-Session IV Report, 24 Sept 2026
- [42] Polymarket, "Fed decision in October" market, direct fetch 24-25 Sept 2026
- [43] Census Bureau, Advance Report on Durable Goods (July 2026 print, prior-month reference)

Method: every figure traces to a named source in Annex B; where sources disagreed, the better-corroborated figure was used and the conflict disclosed. Nothing estimated or filled from memory — unverifiable items are listed in Annex A. Not investment advice.